

THE FRIENDS WITH FOUR KEYS: COLD OPEN, FABLE v0.1

2026-08-31. Written by a fresh Fable 5 subagent fed only the show framing, the five v1.2 verbatim, and Part G of the spine (v1.4). No file access, no repo, no memory. Fable has never seen Parts A to F and does not know which of the four, what was behind the door, or that anyone is alive.

v0.1 is the first return: 388 words, over the 330 cap. Sent back for the cut; v0.2 follows. Kept here so the cut can be seen.

Checks on v0.1: death and keys inside the first 70 words (pass) · no em dashes (pass) · nothing invented outside the brief (pass) · under 330 words (FAIL, 388) · [△](#) names Sergeant Del Cruz on air, and her partnership with Ally is canon-unofficial: flagged for Stephen, and v0.2 was asked to say "a sergeant I trust in Harbor Ward" instead · sign-off reuses "Goodnight, Harbour" from The Listener's close: continuity, not invention.

Timing at 388 words: 2:35 at 150 wpm · 2:47 at 140 · 2:59 at 130.

This is Echoes of Havenbay. I'm Ally Quinn.

Nine months ago, on a Monday night, Violet Moore died at the foot of her own stairs. She was forty-four. She painted letters for a living: shop fronts, boat names, the side of a bus, once, for a bet. Police attended. There was a post-mortem. The coroner called it an accident.

Two weeks after she died, four people got a key in the post, and a letter in her hand. Liam Bryce. Ruby Walker. Margo Rivera. Brad Collins. Her four closest friends. The letter said she thought one of them was planning to kill her. She did not know which. She said she might be wrong. She told them not to go to the police, and she told them why. She said what she had found was behind a door that only the four of them could open.

They opened it together, on the Saturday. Behind it was a second letter. That one said she knew. And beside it, something of hers. The two who are still alive will not tell me what it was. Only that it was hers.

Seven weeks after the funeral, Brad Collins drove to Kestrel Head at night and was never found. Five months later, Margo Rivera's car was in the same car park. Her body came into the harbour three days after that.

Liam Bryce and Ruby Walker each went to the police within the week. Not to accuse. To say: I am frightened of him. I am frightened of her. Sergeant Del Cruz of Harbor Ward told me they looked, properly, for six weeks. The letters are Violet's. Her solicitor confirms she lodged them three weeks before she died. The coroner's finding stands. They found nothing.

Now those two are taking each other apart on the front page of the Gazette, over a dead woman's letter. I wasn't there for any of it. I've never met either of them. Ruby has agreed to talk. Liam hasn't, yet. Before I press record on anyone, I'll ask them, on this microphone, and you'll hear the answer.

I don't know what the police couldn't find. Neither does anyone I've spoken to. But I'd like to sit with the people who loved her, and listen.

You're listening to Echoes of Havenbay. Goodnight, Harbour.

388 words.